Parshas Vayeira - Mesirat Nefesh and Chazakas

Parshas Vayeira has a fascinating theme that runs not only through the parsha itself, but echoes throughout Tanach and even Halacha: the power and pattern of the number three.

We're not talking about it in the silly style of "The Count" from Sesame Street, but rather in a way that's deeply rooted in Jewish thought and practice. The number three carries weight, structure, and meaning.

The Pattern of Three in Torah and Halacha

Across Jewish tradition, we find foundational groupings of three:

- The **6,000 years** of the world are divided into three periods: 2,000 years of tohu (chaos), 2,000 years of Torah, and 2,000 years connected to Mashiach.
- In **Halacha**, a chazakah (presumption of permanence) is established after three consistent occurrences.
- A **Beis Din** (rabbinical court) requires three members.
- A young boy's **chinuch** (Jewish education) formally begins at age three, marked by the upsherin (haircutting ceremony) in many communities.

In this week's parsha, we see several more striking examples:

- Avraham is visited by **three angels** as he recovers from his bris milah.
- Sarah is asked to prepare **three se'ah of flour** for bread.
- Avraham selects **three calves** to serve his guests, one for each angel.

These aren't coincidences; they establish a rhythm and structure that is purposeful and divine.

The Threefold Command of the Akeidah

One of the most profound uses of the number three appears in the command Hashem gives to Avraham regarding the Akeidah:

> **"Kach na es bincha, es yechidcha, asher ahavta, es Yitzchak"**

Please take your son, your only one, whom you love, Yitzchak.
קח נא את בנך את יחידך אשר אהבת את יצחק

This layered directive isn't just poetic. Chazal explain, and further elaborated by Rashi , that Hashem didn't need to go through this list for Avraham's sake. He would've fulfilled a single command without hesitation. It was done in this way to teach the levels of growth and even zechut for each level. The Sfas Emes elaborates further that the progression is for us, the descendants of Avraham. It's a lesson in spiritual growth and is aqlso a gift to us of mesiras nefesh (self-sacrifice) and without it, we may not be on the level of such a z'chus.

Each stage of the phrase represents an increasing level of emotional and spiritual difficulty:

1. **Bincha** – your son. A serious ask, but one might still have more than one child.

2. **Yechidcha** – your only one. Now it becomes unique.

3. **Asher Ahavta** – whom you love. The emotional bond tightens.

Avraham is being asked to give not just a child, but everything: his love, his legacy, his nation's destiny. And yet, he walks forward.

Three Aveyros We Must Be Moser Nefesh For

These three steps above are also a tikkun or balance for the three aveyros we are moser nef

The gemara in Sanhedrin 74a teaches:

אם אומרים לאדם עבור ואל תהרג – עבור ואל יהרג, חוץ מעבודה זרה, וגילוי עריות, ושפיכות דמים

If a person is told, "Transgress rather than be killed," they should transgress and not be killed — except in the cases of **idolatry**, **forbidden relationships**, and **murder**.

These are the **three cardinal sins** for which a Jew must choose death rather than transgression:

- **Idolatry (Avodah Zarah**) - is a betrayal of Hashem as the one true God.

- **Forbidden Relationships (Gilu'i Arayos) -** distorts the sacredness of intimacy and creation.

- **Murder (Shefichas Damim) -** destroys life itself.

Each of these three corresponds with a layer of the Akeidah, and each reflects how creation, holiness, and emotional connection can either be elevated or distorted:

- Bincha – your son. A child can be either the result of a sacred and proper union, a product of kedusha, or the opposite. This contrasts with **Gilu'i Arayos**, which corrupts and perverts that same power of creation. The damage caused by this distortion may be so deep that full teshuva is even harder than giving up one's life.

- Yechidcha – your only one. This singular statement can easily refer to Hashem, the One. In contrast, **Avodah Zarah** replaces the One with something else, assigning divine status to what is not divine. It denies the unsharable uniqueness of Hashem.

- Asher Ahavta – whom you love. This can point to **Shefichas Damim** — not necessarily in the act of murder itself, but in the capacity for unbounded emotion to lead to devastating and even murderous action. Love, when distorted or unchecked, can justify horrors. The American legal system even recognizes crimes of passion as a category. And on the opposite side of love is hate, an emotion so powerful it led to the destruction of the Second Beis Hamikdash.

In this way, the Akeidah models the three forms of ultimate mesiras nefesh, each aligned with one of the gravest prohibitions. But it also shows us something more personal: that our sacrifices today are not always life-or-death, but they can be just as spiritually powerful when they involve giving up from our abundance, from our uniqueness, or from our love.

This idea scales. For some, it's giving up extra time, comforts, or habits. For others, it might be sacrificing ego, control, or dreams. And for all of us, it's a process, moving from easier to harder, from many to one, from what we like to what we love. This is how we grow.

And every Jew, no matter their background, has a way to live out mesiras nefesh. It's not just for tzaddikim or Avos. It's for all of us, at our level, building upward step by step.

Mesiras Nefesh Today: Personal Growth as Sacrifice

Today, we're not usually called to literal self-sacrifice. But we are called to stretch, to give, to grow. Giving tzedakah, our time, unique items, or things we are emotionally connected to — this too is mesiras nefesh.

- Letting go of something you have plenty of? That's one level.

- Giving something precious and unique? That's a deeper level.

- Offering up something you love? That's the ultimate.

It’s easy to speak of faith in the abstract, but the Akeidah teaches us to act on it in tangible ways. Bit by bit, sacrifice by sacrifice, we build ourselves into people who reflect our forefather Avraham.

Alef + Beis: The Three of Av (Father)

One last beautiful group of three: the word **Av** (father), spelled Alef-Beis, אב, has a gematria of 1 and 2, adding up to three. This connects us back to the three Avos: Avraham, Yitzchak, and Yaakov. They form our spiritual DNA.

My daughter once told me sweetly, "Tatti, I have two fathers: you and Hashem." She was trying to express something profound — that our connection to Hashem is intimate, personal, and loving, just like our bond with our own parents.

The Takeaway

These awarenesses from Parshas Vayeira invite us into who and where we are, and the strength we have as individuals. It’s not just a story of angels, or bread, or trials — it’s the lesson of building a soul that can walk in the footsteps of the giants who came before us and led the way.

May we all have a Shabbos of warmth, reflection, and strength. And may our threes always point us upward.

So we ask ourselves:

- Where am I making patterns of three in my life — chazakahs of growth?
- Am I leading like an Av, even if or where I’m not a parent?
- Am I giving from abundance, or giving from love?